

While there are many reputable, law-abiding collection agencies out there, it is best to make yourself aware of the proper recourse should you encounter a stinker. If you experience any problems with an agency violating the laws of the FDCPA, please contact your state attorney general's

office. If you are dealing with an out-of-state agency, you may also call the Federal Trade Commission at 1-877-382-4357 (877-FTC-HELP). Being educated is the key to being protected. Know the law, and you can keep an old debt from ruining your life!

— **Linsey Knerl**